

CHAPTER 1

Section 1.1

النَّحْوُ – Arabic Grammar

Definition:

Nahw is that science, which teaches us how to join a noun, verb and particle to form a correct sentence, as well as what the إِعْرَابُ (condition) of the last letter of a word should be.

Subject Matter:

Its subject matter is كَلِمَةٌ (word) and كَلَامٌ (sentence).

Objective:

- The immediate objective is to learn how to read, write and speak Arabic correctly, and to avoid making mistakes in this. For example, رَزَيْدٌ, دَارٌ, دَخَلَ, and فِي are four words. The science of *Nahw* teaches us how to put them together to form a correct sentence.
- The mid-term objective is to use our Arabic skills to understand the *Qur'an*, *Hadeeth*, *Fiqh* and other Islamic sciences, so that we can act upon them.
- The ultimate objective through the above is to gain the pleasure of Allah Most High.

Section 1.2

الكَلِمَةُ – The Word

Any word uttered by humans is called a لَفْظٌ. If it has a meaning, it is called مَوْضُوعٌ (meaningful); and if it does not have any meaning, it is called مُهْمَلٌ (meaningless).

In Arabic, لَفْظٌ مَوْضُوعٌ (meaningful word) is of two types: مُفْرَدٌ and مُرَكَّبٌ.

1. مُفْرَدٌ – Singular: It is that single word, which conveys one meaning. It is also called كَلِمَةٌ.
2. مُرَكَّبٌ – Compound: It is a group of words. They may form a complete sentence or an incomplete one.

كَلِمَةُ Types of

There are three types of كَلِمَةُ:

1. اِسْمٌ (noun)
2. فِعْلٌ (verb)
3. حَرْفٌ (particle)

اِسْمٌ – Noun:

- It is that كَلِمَةُ whose meaning can be understood without the need to combine it with another word.
- It does not have any tense.¹
- It is the name of a person, place or thing.²

e.g. رَجُلٌ man
الْبَيْتُ house

Note: A noun can never have a تَنْوِينٌ (*tanween*) and an ال at the same time.

¹ The first two bullets combine to form the classical definition of اِسْمٌ. See, for example, ‘Abdullah ibn ‘Aqil, *Sharh ibn ‘Aqil ‘ala Alfyyat ibn Malik*, (Cairo: Dar al-Turath, 1980), vol. 1, 15. The definition given by ibn ‘Aqil is as follows: (الكَلِمَةُ اِنْ دَلَّتْ عَلَى مَعْنًى فِي نَفْسِهَا غَيْرَ مُقْتَرِنٍ بِزَمَانٍ فَهِيَ اِسْمٌ).

² This third bullet by itself is the definition found in more modern texts like *al-Nahw al-Wadih*. See, for example, ‘Ali al-Jaarim & Mustafa Ameen, *al-Nahw al-Wadih li al-Madaris al-Ibtida’iyyah*, (Cairo: Dar al-Ma‘arif, n.d.), vol. 1, 16. Their definition of اِسْمٌ is as follows:

(الْاِسْمُ: كُلُّ لَفْظٍ يُسَمَّى بِهِ اِنْسَانٌ اَوْ حَيَوَانٌ اَوْ نَبَاتٌ اَوْ جَمَادٍ اَوْ اَيُّ شَيْءٍ آخَرَ)

فِعْلٌ – Verb:

- It is that كَلِمَةٌ whose meaning can be understood without the need to combine it with another word.
- It has one of the three tenses: past, present, or future.³
- It denotes an action.⁴

e.g. ضَرَبَ He hit. نَصَرَ He helped.

Note: A فِعْلٌ can never have a تَنْوِينٌ (*tanween*) or an ال.

حَرْفٌ – Particle:

It is that كَلِمَةٌ whose meaning cannot be understood without joining an اِسْمٌ or a فِعْلٌ or both to it.

e.g. مِنْ (from)
 عَلَى (on top)

EXERCISES

1. State with reason whether the following words are حَرْفٌ، فِعْلٌ، اِسْمٌ.

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|-------------------------------|----------------------------------|
| i. جَلَسَ (He sat.) | iii. بِنْتُ (girl) |
| ii. وَ (and) | iv. كَسَرَ (He broke.) |

2. Find the meaning and the plural of the following nouns using a dictionary.

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|-----------------|--------------------|
| i. قَلَمٌ | iii. كِتَابٌ |
| ii. فَصْلٌ | iv. سَبُورَةٌ |

³ The first two bullets combine to form the classical definition of فِعْلٌ. See *Sharh ibn 'Aqil*, vol. 1, 15.

⁴ The last two bullets combine to form the definition of فِعْلٌ as given in *al-Nahw al-Wadih*. See *al-Nahw al-Wadih*, *Ibtida'iyah*, vol. 1, 16.

Section 1.3

أقسام الاسم – Types of Noun

اسم is of three types:

1. جامد – Primary Noun: It is that اسم which is neither derived from another word nor is any word derived from it.

e.g. فَرَسٌ horse بِنْتٌ girl

2. مصدر – Root Noun: It is that اسم from which many words are derived.

e.g. ضَرَبَ to hit نَصَرَ to help

3. مشتق – Derived Noun: It is that اسم which is derived from a *masdar*.

e.g. ضَارِبٌ hitter مَنْصُورٌ the helped

أقسام الفعل – Types of Verb

فعل is of four types:

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|----------------------|----------------------------------|------|--------------|----------------------------|
| 1. الْمَاضِي | Past tense | e.g. | ضَرَبَ | He hit. |
| 2. الْمُضَارِعُ | Present and Future tense | e.g. | يَضْرِبُ | He is hitting or will hit. |
| 3. الْأَمْرُ | Positive Command/
Imperative | e.g. | إِضْرِبْ | Hit! |
| 4. النَّهْيُ | Negative Command/
Prohibitive | e.g. | لَا تَضْرِبْ | Don't hit! |

أقسام الحرف – Types of Particle

حرف is of two types:

1. عامل – Causative Particle: It is that حرف, which causes إِعْرَابٌ change in the word after it.

e.g. زَيْدٌ فِي الْمَسْجِدِ Zayd is in the mosque.

2. غير العامل – Non-Causative: It is that حرف, which does not cause إِعْرَابٌ change in the word after it.

e.g. ثُمَّ then وَ and

EXERCISES

1. Correct the following words (stating a reason) and give its meaning.

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|-----------------|------------------|
| i. الْبَيْتُ | iii. الْوَرَقُ |
| ii. الْفَتْحَ | iv. سَمِعَ |

2. Find the meaning and the plural of the following nouns using a dictionary.

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|-----------------|---------------|
| i. بُسْتَانٌ | iii. بَابٌ |
| ii. قَمَرٌ | iv. كَلْبٌ |

3. Translate the following sentences, and identify the different types of verbs in them.

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|---|---------------------------------------|
| i. فَتَحَ خَالِدٌ الشُّبَّانَ | iii. اُكْتُبَ رِسَالَةٌ |
| ii. يَدْرُسُ أَحْمَدُ فِي الْمَدْرَسَةِ | iv. لَا تَقْرَأُ ذَلِكَ الْكِتَابَ |